

A skill is a **folder with instructions**. The agent reads your **description**, picks the right skill, then **follows your instructions**.

HOW TO ADD A SKILL · 3 STEPS

1

Write the description

One sentence. What does it do AND when should the agent use it?

2

Write the instructions

Plain English rules. Imagine you're training a smart but literal intern.

3

Register & test

Run the cell to register. Ask the agent a question that should trigger it.

COPY-PASTE TEMPLATE

```
SKILLS["your-skill-name"] = {  
    "description": "ONE sentence: what it does + when to use it.",  
    "instructions": ""  
# Your Skill Name  
  
Tell the agent exactly what to do:  
1. First rule  
2. Second rule  
3. What format to return  
4. What to AVOID  
""  
}
```

DESCRIPTION QUALITY · THE #1 THING THAT MATTERS

✗ VAGUE · agent will ignore it

"Writes poems"
"Does math stuff"
"Helps with jokes"

Too broad. The agent can't tell when to pick it.

✓ SPECIFIC · agent will pick it

"Writes a 4-line rhyming rap verse about any topic"
"Solves algebra problems step-by-step"
"Tells a dad joke related to a given word"

Tells the agent WHAT it does AND WHEN to use it.

PLAN ON PAPER FIRST · FILL THIS IN BEFORE YOU TYPE

skill_name: _____

description:

instructions (rules, format, what to avoid):

IF / THEN

The agent ignored my skill.	Fix the description. Make it more specific. Say WHEN to use it, not just what it does. 90% of the time this is the problem.
The agent picked the wrong skill.	Two descriptions overlap. Rewrite them so they clearly cover different territory. Or make your prompt more specific.
<code>no skill named '...' error.</code>	Name mismatch. The key in <code>SKILLS["..."]</code> must match exactly what the agent asked for. Check spelling.
The agent loaded my skill but didn't follow it.	Instructions too vague. Add numbered rules. Tell it what format to return. Tell it what NOT to do.
<code>401 Unauthorized</code> / <code>KeyError: GITHUB_TOKEN</code>	Token problem. Re-run the getpass cell. If still broken, regenerate a token at github.com/settings/tokens with zero scopes.
<code>429 Too Many Requests</code>	Slow down. Wait 60 seconds. The free tier allows ~15 requests/minute. You're fine; just pause.
The agent hit the step limit.	Probably infinite loop. Your skill may be telling the agent to load another skill that doesn't exist. Check the instructions.

PROMPTS TO TRY (AFTER YOU WRITE A SKILL)

DIRECT MATCH Ask exactly what your skill does, using the same words from the description.	INDIRECT MATCH Ask something the skill should handle — without using its name. Does the agent still pick it?
NO MATCH Ask something NO skill can handle. The agent should answer normally without loading any skill.	COMPOUND Ask for two things, each needing a different skill. Does the agent chain them?

POWER MOVES · TRY THESE IF YOU'RE AHEAD

Make your description terrible on purpose.	Watch the agent stop picking your skill. Then fix it. This is the best way to build intuition for what works.
Swap the model.	Change <code>MODEL = "openai/gpt-4o-mini"</code> to <code>"microsoft/phi-4"</code> or <code>"meta/llama-3.3-70b-instruct"</code> . Same code, different brain.
Write a skill that hits a real API.	Your instructions can tell the agent to format a URL like <code>api.agify.io/?name=...</code> and report back the result.

MY NOTES

WHAT I BUILT · WHAT I LEARNED · QUESTIONS

The model picks. Your code runs. That's the safety boundary.

built with GitHub Models · free · no credit card